Alefiya J Malubhoy (A0226616E)
EN3221: The English Renaissance
Dr Walter Lim
4 March 2023

The Body's Betrayal:
Falsity in 'The Duchess of Malfi'

> *"[…] yet believe't,*
> *Your darkest actions, nay your privatest thoughts,*
> *Will come to light*."
>
> — John Webster
> The Duchess of Malfi
> (1.2.224-225)

Webster's 1613 tragedy, 'The Duchess of Malfi', is rife with secrets and duplicity. Characters play at pretend in their interactions with other characters to maintain a façade, but I argue that all the characters in the play are unable to maintain their falsity because their underlying natures are made apparent by their bodily instincts. In other words, I am positing that the body betrays and exposes the truth within the text, to the characters themselves, other characters and the audience.

Falsity and Hypocrisy

Falsity is inherent to 'The Duchess of Malfi' – the text itself immediately thrusts us into the world of duplicity and lies with its setting, Amalfi in Italy, which to the contemporary reader during the English Renaissance would signal the ideas of 'sophisticated corruption'. The moral impression of Italy at the time, too, was a paradox unto itself (as paralleled in the character of the Cardinal): it was simultaneously associated with religion, as the birthplace of Catholicism, as well as radical and blasphemous icons like Machiavelli. This theme of moral corruption and falsity in the political workings of Italy is plainly introduced to us in the exposition.

Antonio, freshly returned to Italy from France, draws a stark juxtaposition between the political workings of each court. The French system is honest and lawful, likened to "a common fountain whence should flow / Pure silver drops in general" (1.1.12-13), and can only be sullied if the

head of the fountain, the monarch, is poisonous. The head of Italian society, on the other hand, is already poisoned: Ferdinand, the Duke of Calabria, seems to be an eloquent and light-hearted conversationalist with his courtiers, but Antonio reveals to us that "What appears in him mirth is merely outside" (2.1.81) – in reality, he is a manipulative and cruel man who uses other people for his own personal gain. His brother, a Cardinal of the Church, is rumoured to be a brave man who gambles, flirts and fights but these "flashes superficially hang on him, for form" (2.1.69) because he is actually a jealous and scheming character. Thus, the perfectly crafted public personas of both Ferdinand and the Cardinal are dismantled before the audience's eyes by Antonio's words in the first instance.

As the play launches into its plot, we see that the rot, so to speak, goes to the core – the brothers' thirst for power and control is not just political, but extends into the domestic sphere as well. They impose cruel restrictions on their sister, the titular Duchess of Malfi, and make her vow not to remarry for vague notions of honour and reputation. They are so conniving and deeply mistrusting of her that they employ Bosola to spy on her for them. The Duchess, for the most part[1], does not respond to her brothers' comments, but immediately after having this conversation with them, she marries Antonio. With this action, not only is she rejecting her brothers' injunction not to marry, but also disdaining their notions of blood purity and reputation, since Antonio is a man below her in class yet she was the one who pursued him.

The play then works to explore the complex machinations that each character works on the others: the Duchess attempts to conceal her marriage to Antonio, the brothers' conceal their hypocritical natures and evil motivations from both the courtiers and their sister, Bosola conceals his true identity as a spy for the brothers and, later, when he is moved to the Duchess' cause, conceals this from the Cardinal while still pretending to follow his orders. However, as I will show in the rest of this paper, their concealments are ultimately futile because the body betrays the soul: the involuntary and undisguisable biological instinct of each character constantly threatens their facades and showcases their true desires, sometimes unbeknownst to themselves.

[1] At 2.1.211-12, she promises she will not remarry; however, there is debate about whether she was agreeing to her brothers' requests or she was unable to finish her full dialogue.

The Betraying Body

I am arguing that because the instinct of the body is uncontrollable and unmediated by the false masks that each character puts on, it is the body that betrays the truth of each character. This concern shows itself most explicitly in the character of Bosola who, like Antonio, is shown to be able to easily see through the facades of characters. Bosola's rejection of falsity and imperial authority is often associated with macabre imagery of the diseased and decaying body – he muses about how humans "continually bear about us / A rotten and dead body, we delight / To hide it in rich tissue" (2.1.53-5), likens the brothers to overly sweet fruit-trees that are fed upon by parasites (1.1.49), tells the Duchess that her coffin will just be "a box of worm food" (4.2.118), and in his dying breath says that dead people, or corpses, are just "dead walls, or vaulted graves / That ruined, yields no echo" (5.5.104-5). Thus, Bosola constantly reminds the audience that there is something beyond falsity, because ultimately everybody is reduced to a physical body.

Bosola adeptness at detecting falsity in other characters is carried out chiefly by examining their physical characteristics, as seen in Act II Scene 1. He immediately notices that the Old Lady has put on makeup to hide her blemished face (2.1.20), and keenly observes the symptoms of the Duchess's pregnancy (2.1.60-3). He contrives to use her body against her by giving her apricots, which were thought to appeal to a pregnant woman's tastes and induce labour. Indeed, the Duchess gives birth soon after ingesting the apricots – the secret of her marriage and pregnancy is hence betrayed by her body to Bosola.

This theme of the body's betrayal of secrets is apparent in the evil brothers as well. Ferdinand is emblematic of the body ridden with disease as a symptom of guilt: he goes insane and is diagnosed with lycanthropy by a doctor after he has his twin sister murdered. His wolf-disease seems like a narrative progression of his previous outbursts, triggered by talk of the Duchess' sexuality, which are so violent and animalistic in nature that even the Cardinal calls Ferdinand "deformed [and] beastly" (2.5.58). Critics have mapped Ferdinand's anger and lycanthropy as a projection of his repressed incestuous desires for the Duchess (Lim), a reading that I take to be compatible with my argument – despite his attempt at concealment, Ferdinand's true desire for his sister is betrayed by his unreasonable anger and obsession, pathologized as lycanthropy by the text.

The Cardinal, on the other hand, remains elusive in his motivations to the end of the play, and seems to show little remorse for his actions. However, I argue that his duplicity is exposed more subtly than the other characters. The Cardinal refuses to be publicly seen with Bosola (1.2.135) because he has previously engaged him to commit a murder – almost as if he fears that his *physical* presence near Bosola will betray his guilt. Similarly, his scenes with his mistress, Julia, take place only in private rooms, which is suggestive of the underlying premise that his lust for Julia would reveal their affair; he even admits that he "watched [her] / Like a tame elephant" when she was with her husband (2.4.31-2).



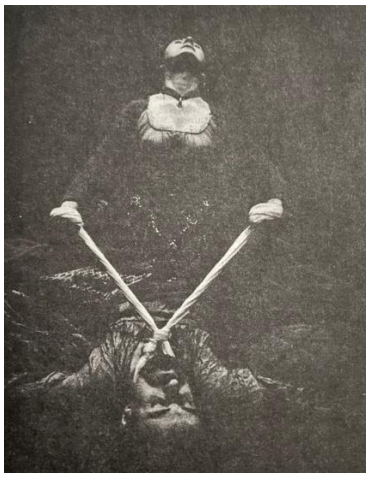


Figure 1. The Cardinal makes Julia kiss a poisoned Bible. John Haynes, 1995 *Cheek by Jowl* production.

Figure 2. Julia and the Cardinal in the 1980 Manchester Royal Exchange Production.

The Cardinal's physical lust for Julia betrays his hypocrisy as a pious member of the Church and, indeed, many productions have taken advantage of the play's sparse stage directions to portray the deeply perverse nature of the Cardinal, often blurring the lines of violence and sex (see Figure 1 and 2). Interestingly, even Julia is not free from the curse of the body: when she tries to play double agent to help Bosola, she is unable to keep her instinctual disgust for the Cardinal's actions to herself when she extracts his confession for the Duchess's murder (5.2.272).

Bosola himself is betrayed by his body at the height of the text, which marks his defection from the brothers' cause to the Duchess's and sets the stage for the violent end of the play. He is unable to make peace with his participation in the cruelty of the Duchess and her children's murders, and is disgusted by the lack of remorse that Ferdinand shows (4.2). His guilt manifests as he watches

the Duchess die through tears that seem to come unbidden to his eyes. He repents that these tears never showed themselves while she was still living because “they were frozen up” (4.2.355), implying that his guilt was always hidden within him but only made itself apparent through his emotional reaction. It is the bodily betrayal of his tears that show to him and the audience that his genuine loyalty is to the Duchess.

Conclusion

In this paper, I have put forth the idea that characters in the play ‘The Duchess of Malfi’ are, due to political or personal reasons, engaged in a complex web of lies. Each character maintains a façade in front of other characters; however, I argue that these facades are dismantled by physical instincts that they cannot control. Thus, the recurring image of rotting, diseased body that Bosola injects into the play serves to remind the reader that the physical body persists in honesty despite a person’s put-upon falsity. The body acts as a symptom of the truth. It betrays the soul of each character: the Duchess’s pregnancy, the Cardinal’s lust, Bosola’s tears, and Ferdinand’s lycanthropy are all products of biological, physical processes which ultimately expose their falsities in the text.

Word Count: 1554 (excluding in-text citations and footnotes).

References

Lim, Walter. *Duchess of Malfi: Lecture 1*. p. 14.

Webster, John. *Plays in Performance: The Duchess of Malfi*. Edited by Kathleen McLuskie and Jennifer Uglow, Bristol Classical Press, 1989.